

HARGROVE

IDEAL CLIENT PROFILE

A guide for financial advisors on who to refer and when



Estate planning is one of the most effective ways to deepen client relationships and uncover wallet share. When a client goes through the planning process, their full asset picture comes into view—accounts, property, business interests, and family wealth that may only be partially under your management today. Advisors who make estate planning a consistent part of their practice are building a more complete picture of every client's financial life, and creating opportunities to bring more of it in-house.

This guide summarizes what the data shows about which clients are most likely to complete the estate planning process, and the referral behaviors that make the biggest difference in getting them there.

Who: The Clients Most Likely to Complete a Plan

The single strongest predictor: they have people to protect.

Clients with dependent children reach a consultation at 82% (vs. 39% without dependents) and, once in a consultation, purchase a plan at 83% (clients without dependents purchase at 17%).¹ This doesn't mean childless clients shouldn't be referred—it means that when you're thinking about which clients to prioritize, family structure is your most reliable signal.

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Clients with dependent children reach a consultation

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Once in a consultation, purchase a plan

¹ This data comes from internal analysis of plans completed via Hargrove Firm as of April 28, 2026.

In order of impact, the client profile that converts most consistently looks like this:

01

Married with minor children — the highest-converting segment by a significant margin. The existence of children—not the complexity of the estate—is the trigger that creates motivation to act.

02

Blended families (children from prior relationships) — convert at nearly the same rate as married-with-kids, and may have more urgency because the planning complexity is real and visible to them.

03

Business owners with significant assets — clients with an LLC, S-corp, buy-sell agreement, or significant property holdings often have estate planning complexity that makes the engagement feel necessary rather than optional. While the data doesn't show a meaningfully higher conversion rate for this group specifically, they tend to have clear stakes and a tangible reason to act.

04

Recently married or remarried — a life transition that often prompts clients to think about estate planning for the first time, particularly when assets or children from prior relationships are involved. Refer when the dust has settled enough that they have bandwidth to engage.

Clients who are less likely to convert:

- Singles without dependents convert at roughly 1 in 6. It's not impossible, but they are a lower-probability referral.
- Clients who already have an estate plan and are referred for a "review" without a specific reason to update it tend to stall. If your client already has an estate plan and you believe they'd benefit from an update, the best thing to do is flag that in a note when you make the referral so we can approach the conversation accordingly.

When: Timing Can Make a Difference

Make a note if a client needs extra time to complete their plan

Fit is the primary driver of conversion, but timing matters too. Clients referred when they're mid-crisis—going through a divorce, hospitalization, or interstate move—often have the motivation to do estate planning but not the bandwidth to execute right now. When that happens, the engagement tends to stall.

That said, referring early is still better than not referring at all. If a client isn't ready to engage immediately, we can keep them warm and follow up when the moment is right. The goal isn't to wait for a perfect window, but rather to flag the context when you add them so we can adjust our approach accordingly.

If you do know a client is mid-transition, noting that in the referral note helps us tailor our communications to fit their circumstances.



How: Behaviors that Drive Conversion

Write a referral note when you add the client

Clients with an advisor note before the consult reach a meeting at 68% vs. 58% without one.² The note doesn't need to be long—a few sentences about family structure, assets, existing documents, and the reason the client is acting now is plenty. It helps the attorney prepare, makes the consultation more productive, and helps the client have a more seamless experience with a level of familiarity in place from the first meeting.

Here's what effective referral notes look like in practice:

"Tom has 3 children from a previous marriage. Current estate plan is basic Wills only. In addition to updated core documents, we've discussed adding asset protection trusts for the kids."

"Client recently had a child and is looking to establish a trust to make sure his child and partner are taken care of."

"Moved to SC from NY and would like to update their wills, POAs, and Medical Directives."

"Net worth has grown from \$6M to \$17M in the past 5 years—looking to redo their revocable living trust."

"Just remarried. Has 3 sons from prior marriage. Looking to update estate plan to reflect new family structure."

Prime the client before our initial consultation

When price comes up for the first time in the consultation, conversion drops—meetings where cost is discussed convert at 60% vs. 68% where it isn't.³ It's unlikely that this is due to a lack of resources to cover the cost; the more likely explanation is surprise. A client who already has a rough sense of the fee range walks into the meeting ready to make a decision rather than processing new information.

Scripting this isn't necessary. A brief heads-up is sufficient: something like "it's a flat fee, in the \$3,000–\$6,000 range depending on your situation." A brief mention that you've personally referred them, along with what to expect from the process, also helps. We will share this as well.

^{2, 3} This data comes from internal analysis of plans completed via Hargrove Firm as of April 28, 2026.

In Plain Terms

The clients who complete the estate planning process have something at stake, a specific reason to act now, and an advisor who told them it was worth doing. When those three things are present, the process works well. When they're absent—particularly when the client doesn't have a concrete reason to act, or was referred while mid-crisis—the process tends to stall.



Would you like to discuss clients who might be a good fit, or have questions about the process? Reach out to our Director of Relationship Management, Mo Zoubi, at mzoubi@hargrovemso.com.

This guide is intended for financial advisor use only and reflects general trends based on **Hargrove Firm's internal data**. It is not legal advice and should not be relied upon as a substitute for individualized legal counsel. Every client's situation is unique, and only a licensed attorney can advise on the specific planning strategies appropriate for a given client.

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